
Todd Blanche's dangerous lie sets the stage for more DOJ abuses

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The act itself — appointing a crony and longtime friend to an important government job — was not unusual. It's not even unprecedented for them to appoint family members. (See: Kennedy, President John F. and Attorney General Robert F.) But Donald Trump's [appointment of Todd Blanche](#), his former criminal defense attorney, as attorney general may be a first, and not because Blanche has been a close associate. What's striking about it is the fact that the president needed a criminal defense attorney in the first place.

On Sunday Blanche made his first appearance since his confirmation on ["Meet the Press"](#), and from the first seconds of the interview he made it clear that his new, permanent position would not change his understanding of [his role as the president's apparatchik](#). When host Kristen Welker pressed him on whether he would act independently, Blanche did not mince words. "No, I'm not going to pledge that," he said. "No attorney general should ever pledge that."

Blanche clearly believes that his job is to run the Justice Department by doing the president's bidding. But he did take time to assure the country that Trump had never, and would never, ask him to do anything unethical or illegal, so we needn't worry our pretty little heads about that. "There is this extraordinarily false narrative that the president wakes up in the morning and calls me and says, 'Todd, go prosecute X or Y,'" Blanche said. "He does not do that. He has never done that. He will never do that."

Well, we know that isn't true, don't we? Aside from the mountain of evidence of Trump's unethical, vengeful public rhetoric, we also have the September 2025 Truth Social draft post he [mistakenly published](#) in which he demanded that then-Attorney General Pam Bondi prosecute his political enemies, saying "They're all guilty as hell" and complaining "They impeached me twice, and indicted me (5 times!), OVER NOTHING. JUSTICE MUST BE SERVED, NOW!!!" Ultimately, Bondi was fired in part for failing to get the indictments he ordered for former FBI director James Comey, California Sen. Adam Schiff and New York Attorney General Letitia James. Blanche won't make that same mistake.

When Welker asked him how he squares his and the president's commitment to prosecute anyone who "inappropriately touches" a law enforcement officer after Trump's pardons of the violent Jan. 6 criminals, Blanche essentially replied that pardons are the president's business and they have nothing to do with him. (In fact, the Justice Department's Office of the Pardon Attorney has traditionally had [oversight of the process](#).) Unfortunately, Welker didn't point this out in a follow-up, nor did she ask him about his role as deputy attorney general in overseeing the firings of the department's prosecutors and staff members who worked on the Jan. 6 cases.

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The irony is that this is exactly the kind of interference in the Justice Department that precipitated the rules and norms that call for the attorney general to operate at arm's length from the White House. Admittedly, it's a complicated role; the attorney general is a prominent member of the Cabinet, but is also expected to act independently. Some have been more successful at that than others, and at times attorneys general on both sides of the aisle have been thorns in the side of the presidents they serve.

In the 1990s, Janet Reno's [liberal use of the independent counsel statute](#), which resulted in several investigations against the Clinton administration, caused the president and his staff heartburn. But although he may have groused privately, Bill Clinton did not retaliate against her; Reno remained at the Justice Department throughout his two terms. On the other hand, John Ashcroft's [refusal to allow](#) the George W. Bush administration to override the Justice Department's finding that a covert domestic surveillance program was illegal — which included a “showdown” at the severely ill Ashcroft's hospital bedside in March 2004 — helped ensure he was replaced in Bush's second term.

By and large, administrations respected the formal guardrails that were enacted in the wake of Watergate, which saw Richard Nixon manipulate the Justice Department for his own political protection.

After the so-called Saturday Night Massacre on Oct. 20, 1973, which saw Nixon fire the special prosecutor investigating the Watergate break-in, and subsequent revelations of Nixon's abuses of power — including the fact that his Attorney General John Mitchell was personally involved in the planning of the Watergate break-in — Congress enacted a series of reforms to insulate the Justice Department from political pressure and interference. The Justice Department itself created guidelines to make the department a [“neutral zone”](#) to ensure that while the president could set national law enforcement goals, the White House would not be involved in specific investigations and prosecutions.

For the most part, administrations stuck to those regulations for decades, although the Republicans started pushing the envelope even before Trump came along. Recall that in 2007 Bush's second attorney general, Alberto Gonzales, was forced to resign when it became known that he had [fired several U.S. attorneys](#) when they failed to follow orders to go after Democratic politicians on dubious charges before elections.

While serious, even that is small potatoes to how Trump has blown the guidelines to smithereens. Like Nixon, Trump sees the Justice Department as a personal law firm that possesses all the power of the U.S. government to use for his own purposes. And since vengeance against his enemies is his top priority, the department is his chosen weapon.

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At every step of the way — from deputy to acting attorney general, and now to holding the post in his own right following his narrow Senate confirmation — Todd Blanche has acted in Trump's interest over that of the people of the United States. In further insult to the public, Blanche [told NBC](#) in April that they should be “happy” Trump is meddling in matters of the Justice Department. In his various roles, Blanche has [helped cover up the Epstein files](#), and he personally signed a memorandum of understanding assuring the president that he and his family would [never face an IRS audit again](#). Since he took office as deputy attorney general, some 16,000 to 20,000 personnel have [left the Justice Department](#), apparently unwilling to go along with an edict bearing his imprimatur that Donald Trump is their [“chief client.”](#) Here, they'd been thinking their chief client was the American people.

During his interview with Welker, Blanche attempted to spin his refusal to ensure the department's

independence from Trump. “If I were to pledge I were to be independent of the White House, what that means is that if President Trump says, ‘I want the Department of Justice to go after every violent criminal in this country, which is what he has said — what you’re saying to me is I should say, ‘No sir, I’m not gonna do it,’” Blanche said. “So I will act with integrity, our prosecutors will act with integrity, we will prosecute without fear or any sort of favor, and that’s exactly what we have been doing.”

With over two years left in Trump’s presidency, I can’t even begin to contemplate what Blanche will do on his behalf. Whatever happens will be cloaked in lies — and followed by gaslighting.

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